



Rugby River Champions Individual Volunteer Information Sheet

Overview

Rugby River Champions (RRC) is a citizen science project led by the University of Birmingham and Rugby Borough Council.

We are connecting with volunteers and pre-existing volunteer groups across Rugby, providing the training and equipment to monitor different aspects of river health. We suggest groups commit about 1-2 hours per month.

RRC Monitoring and Participation

Individuals over 18 years can fully participate in the RRC project, and can do so by completing [this sign up form](#).

Before signing up, volunteers should consider the physical demands of the different monitoring techniques. The most exhaustive exercise is the 3-minute 'kick sample' in Urban Riverfly, but only one volunteer per session (ideally the same person each time). The other physical actions required during RRC monitoring includes bending down to sample water and walking along riverbanks.

Volunteers can choose to participate in whichever monitoring technique they feel physically and mentally able to undertake. Individuals making up the group's sampling team (including the group leads) can vary between dates, and those attending should only do so when they are free and willing to participate.

We advise that volunteers should repeat Urban Riverfly and water chemistry sampling every month where possible. For individual volunteers, the Project Officer will support the coordination of sampling sessions. Any volunteer undertaking RRC monitoring can upload citizen science data via our online form (link to be shared in coming weeks).

Individuals can withdraw from the initiative at any time by informing the RRC project team, who will then remove their name and email address from our records (see below for further information).



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Participants under the ages of 18 and 16

Minors must always have a parent or guardian with them when participating in Birmingham River Champion training, as well as when participating with Birmingham River Champion activities.

It is recommended that two adults are present when a minor is supporting river monitoring, both for health and safety purposes and for safeguarding.

Minors must not handle nitrate, phosphate or ammonia testing apparatus at any time. During training, it is the trainer's responsibility to ensure that minor participants are wearing appropriate clothing to carry out any river monitoring activity. Trainers may refuse to train a group if individuals do not have suitable clothing.

Outside of training, it is the responsibility of the minors' parent or guardian to ensure suitable clothing is worn when monitoring.

Outside of Birmingham River Champion training sessions, safeguarding will be per the individual volunteer groups safeguarding policy. If a volunteer group does not have a safeguarding policy, then working with minors is not recommended.

Under 16s:

Under 16s must not enter the river under any circumstances.

Under 16s are not permitted to carry out any chemical testing (including nitrate, phosphate, ammonia, temperature, electrical conductivity, or turbidity testing).

Under 16s may support with Bank side observational monitoring.

16-17s

16-17s may be permitted to enter the water with parent/guardian consent. As well as reading the health and safety information provided pre-training, under 16-17s should be given a verbal health and safety briefing before entering the water.

Please email us via RugbyRiverChampions@gmail.com to discuss someone under the age of 18 participating.



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Privacy Information

When signing up to the RRC, individual volunteers will need to provide their name and email address, which will be stored in a password-protected electronic spreadsheet held by the RRC project leads within the University of Birmingham's secure OneDrive storage environment.

These details will be stored alongside whether or not the individual wishes to subscribe to the mailing list, where subscribers will receive useful information, help and updates on the project (at roughly monthly to quarterly intervals). Individuals can subscribe or unsubscribe from the mailing list at any point.

The names and email addresses of individual volunteers will not be shared with any third parties.

Health and Safety

Health and safety is of paramount importance and every individual within a volunteer group undertaking RRC monitoring should comply with the following health and safety procedures.

Volunteers should ensure they have read and understood the health and safety information below and a separate risk assessment provided before undertaking monitoring. Once that you are signed up to the RRC project, you will be covered by the University's public liability insurance and employers liability insurance when monitoring.

Please follow the following guidance when completing any surveying:

- When working in or near water. never work alone. Always have another person in attendance.
- Only access water at easy-to-access locations.
- Only sample at locations where water is below welly height.
- Check riverbed before entering to ensure stable materials are underfoot.
- Please check the weather forecast before you sample.
- If water levels rise rapidly, abort sampling immediately.
- Check for and avoid any sharp and cumbersome materials and any potentially dangerous or hazardous features (e.g., needles, syringes) in the water.
- Check for and avoid **giant hogweed** along riverbanks (its sap can cause nasty burns), and any other **toxic plants** whilst monitoring.



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- Broken skin should be covered with a waterproof dressing.
- Hands should be washed after sampling and before eating, drinking or smoking to reduce chances of illness.
- Practising good sanitation is important for reducing the chances of contracting **Weils disease** (or Leptospirosis).
- Extra precautions (e.g., wearing disposable gloves) should be adopted when sampling rivers surrounded by pasture that likely contain animal urine.
- Wear long sleeved clothing when walking through grassy or woodland areas and check for ticks after sampling.
- Be aware of the symptoms of **Lymes disease** and seek medical attention if any symptoms are present.
- Extra caution should be exercised when undertaking water chemistry sampling as some techniques use dangerous solutions.

Further information on all of this health and safety information can be found within the BRC risk assessment that will be emailed to all volunteer group leads and volunteers under their direction.

Contact Us

If you have any questions about the project please contact Caroline Roper at rugbyriverchampions@gmail.com



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